3.2 Seven Sisters

Hello, everyone! Have you guessed who we are? We are the Seven Sisters of Northeast India, still unexplored, isolated territories to most of you and to the rest of the world. Our sister Sikkim lies to the north, but we seven sisters are contiguous to each other. We are famous for our natural beauty, lush forests and wild animals as well as our colourful costumes, traditional jewellery, exotic flowers and our own unique dance and music. Nature lovers have designated our whole area as one of the world's biodiversity hotspots.

Now we will introduce ourselves one by one.

Arunachal Pradesh

Hi, they call me the Land of the Rising Sun – the Land of the Dawn Lit Sun! I am Arunachal Pradesh. My people are simple and hospitable. They belong to many tribes speaking their own languages.

Their diet is largely made up of rice with fish, meat and many green vegetables; and a popular dish is *momos* – steamed buns with meat or vegetable stuffing.

I am a nature lovers' heaven. My land is spotted with monasteries, lush green forests, lakes, waterfalls and deep river valleys. In my limestone caves (known as *tapenuru*) and forest reserves, you will find a great variety of wild life.

You must make it a point to visit the 400 year old Buddhist monastery at Tawang and enjoy cultural festivals at Ziro. Don't miss the Namdapha tiger project. You are also welcome to the many wild life sanctuaries and national parks where you may see rare animals, birds and plants. I am also home to India's first orchid sanctuary.

Assam

Friends! I am Assam, also known as Ahom. You will find my land between the beautiful valleys of the Brahmaputra and Barak rivers. They call me the gateway to the seven sisters.

My people are very hospitable. If you come here you can enjoy the cuisine which has its own distinctive aromas and flavours. I am known for my artistic heritage, exotic dance forms and elegant temples.

The rivers ensure that my territory is lush and fertile, with wetlands, orchards, tea estates, and scenic forests and parks. Kaziranga National Park and Manas National Park are World Heritage Sites. My picturesque landscape of golden-green rice fields and landscaped tea estates is awesome to behold! And you know, Assam tea is world famous!

The Brahmaputra is Assam's lifeline. The land is also rich in petroleum, natural gas, coal, limestone and other minor minerals.

My hand woven silks are exquisite, with natural colours and designs. They say our women weave fairy tales on their looms! Assam's silk fabrics 'Eri', 'Muga' and 'Pat' are the most sought after silks in the world of fashion.

I am known as the land of fairs and festivals. The major festival of Assam is Bihu.

Cane and bamboo are the inseparable parts of my life. As souvenirs you can take the *Jappi* (traditional sunshade) and masks. Don't forget to visit the Ahom palaces.

Meghalaya

Hello friends, I am the abode of clouds, Meghalaya. My capital city Shillong is called 'Scotland of the East' because of its highlands, fog and scenery. My people speak English,

Words to remember and use : • distinctive • exotic • elegant • scenic

Khasi, Pnar and Garo. I am overwhelmingly beautiful, and everything here is impossibly green and alive. The rolling mists in the valleys, the undulating hills, numerous lakes, waterfalls, caves, sacred forests and exotic flora and fauna are fascinating.

Here, Jhum or shifting cultivation is practised even today. I have lovely mountains, with stretches of valley and highland plateaus. The rock formations here contain rich deposits of valuable minerals like coal, limestone, uranium and sillimanite. I have many rivers.

Please come to see Cherrapunji/Mausinram – the wettest places on earth. You can enjoy the forests and 'sacred groves' here.

I boast of several National Parks and Wildlife Sanctuaries. Friends, you would be amazed to see the Krem Liat Prah which is the longest cave, and Synrang Pamiang which is the deepest cave. You can enjoy the panoramic view of Bangladesh from here. Do come to this pine-fresh mountain state during the Wangala festival in autumn.

Manipur

Hey! I am the fourth sister, Manipur, the Jewelled Land. (I am proud to be the jewel of my mother India). I am also known by my nick names Kangleipak or Sanaleibak.

My capital is Imphal where you can see the cyclists' velodrome. Many of my people belong to the Meetei ethnic group and speak Meetei/Manipuri language. I have the credit of introducing polo to the Europeans.

My people's staple diet consists of rice, fish, large varieties of leafy vegetables (both aquatic and terrestrial). But our cuisine is so different from the rest of India, due to the use of various

- picturesque
- awesome
- exquisite
- overwhelmingly
- impossibly

aromatic herbs and roots that are peculiar to my state.

Blessed with an amazing variety of flora and fauna, I am home to a host of rare endemic plant and animal life here. A treat for the eyes is the Keibul Lamjao National Park, an abode of the rare and endangered species of brow antlered deer. This ecosystem contains 17 rare species of mammals. It is the only floating national park of the world. You should come to see the Loktak Lake and Floating Islands.

Our Manipuri dance is one of the most acclaimed classical dances of India. The folk dances of tribal people captivate the beholders with their exotic costumes and simple but graceful rhythm. You should not fail to witness the Manipuri Martial Arts – 'Thang Ta' and 'Sarit Sarak'.

Mizoram

Hello! I am Mizoram. Mizoram implies 'land of the hill people' referred to as the Kukis. I invite you to see my land of lush hills, sheer cliffs, serene lakes and waterfalls. Rolling hills stretch across hundreds of miles, and the plains and valleys are covered with lush forests and thick bamboo groves, green paddy fields, vine yards, teeming with diverse wild life. My regret is that not many of you come to visit me! Well, travelling in Mizoram is a little difficult, but it has its own rewards. The natural beauty here is exquisite and must be seen to be believed!

My capital is Aizawl, and from its scenic location, you can get a captivating view of lush emerald Tlawng river valley in the west and the Tuirial river valley in the east. The museum in the heart of the city, Zarkawt, portrays the culture of Mizoram with a splendid collection of costumes, artefacts and historical relics.

- fascinating
- lovely
- panoramic
- aromatic
- amazing
- rare

The Palak lake is the biggest in Mizoram and covers 30 hectares (74 acres). Do you know that it is believed that the lake was created as a result of an earthquake or a flood? Champhai, with its fertile vineyards, is known as 'the fruit bowl' of Mizoram. I am also host to numerous species of birds, wildlife and flora. You can visit the two national parks and six wildlife sanctuaries here.

Mizo is the official language and the most widely used language.

Nagaland

Hello! I am Nagaland, one of the smallest States of India, called the Switzerland of the East. Here, we have a land of folklore passed down through generations, with music as an integral part of our life. The exquisitely picturesque landscapes, the vibrantly colourful sunrise and sunset, lush and verdant flora make my land unimaginably beautiful.

The State capital is Kohima. The State is mostly mountainous. Mount Saramati is the highest peak with a height of about 3,840 metres and its range forms a natural barrier between Nagaland and Burma.

There are over 16 tribes and sub-tribes that inhabit my exotic hill State, each with its own unique colourful and intricately designed costumes, jewellery and beads that adorn them. Today, many of my young people have ventured into fashion designing, creating fabrics that blend our traditional motifs with modern appeal. So much so, I have become a paradise for those who are into fashion designing. People refer to me as an affluent fashion station of the East.

My land is an ideal place for trekking, rock climbing, jungle camping and offers limitless exploration possibilities in its lush and verdant

- acclaimed
- graceful
- serene
- splendid
- vibrantly

sub-tropical rain forests. Here we have an abundance of medicinal herbs too.

I am known as the 'Falcon capital of the world.' The great Indian hornbill is one of the most famous birds found here.

Nagas, by nature, are lovers of fun and frolic and here, life is one long festival. Dance and songs are a part and parcel of all our festivities. Most of our dances are performed with a robust rhythm. If you love a colourful life and appreciate ethnic customs and traditions with their unique songs, dances and festivals, you must come to our Naga Heritage Village, which showcases our cultural heritage. Do come and participate in our Great Hornbill Festival!

Tripura

Hello, I am Tripura, the third smallest State in the country, bordered by Bangladesh to the north, south, and west,

Tripura meaning 'three cities' 'Tripura' also means 'near water'. Some scholars also believe that the land was ruled in ancient times by a King named Tripur, from whom my name emerged.

My land has three distinct geographical zones: 1. The hill ranges which run from North to South; 2. The undulating plateau land and 3. The low-lying alluvial plains. Many rivers nourish my land and sustain the activities of my people. Chief among them are the Gumti, the Muhuri and the Feni. Rice, cotton, jute, tea, tobacco and oilseeds are grown here.

The Kokborok speaking Tripuri people are the major group among the many tribes and subtribes. Bengali and Manipuri people have co-existed in peaceful harmony with the people of Tripura for generations.

- unimaginably
- verdant
- robust
- peaceful
- gorgeous

I am rather difficult for you to access because only one major road or National Highway connects my land with the rest of the country. Agartala is my capital city. People come to visit me for ecotourism and archaeological tourism. My lush tea gardens and wild life sanctuaries and my specially set up eco-parks are a great attraction; as are the famous rock carvings at Deotamura. The Neermahal is a gorgeous red-and-white water palace, empty but shimmering on its own island in the lake of Rudrasagar.

People of all communities and tribes participate in State festivals like Garia, Durga Puja, Buddha Purnima, Kharchi, Pous Sankranti, Bijhu or Christmas.

Come and visit me; you will be fascinated by my rich cultural heritage, beautiful palaces, wild life sanctuaries, historical temples, palaces and museums. My folk dances will enthrall you, and my people will welcome you with warmth and courtesy!

POINTERS

1. Present any one of the speeches given above.

2. Choose any one of the seven States. Find more information about it and prepare a leaflet or brochure to invite people to visit it.

3. From the passage, find and write any two examples of the following:
   (a) Use of the verb 'be' (am, is, are, etc) as the main verb.
   (b) Sentences containing • 'must' • 'can'.
   (c) Sentences beginning with 'Don't'.

4. Write a short speech for the State of Maharashtra.